collective ethical claims, interests, and emotions, or claims of superior knowledge, most ideologies avoid testability by surpassing everyday experience (Mann 2005). Ideological discourses are efficient in justifying a particular course of social action and in legitimizing or contesting existing power relations, thus it is important to focus on the ideological processes through which 'ethnic identity' is naturalized as the self-evident, legitimate point of reference to make sense of the world we try to understand (Malešević 2013). Rather than focusing on 'ethnic identity', the key issue in Myanmar appears to be how power is framed and contested in relation to processes of identification (Malešević 2006). What is at stake is the ideological question of managing political power that is "inherently territorial, authoritative and monopolistic" (Mann 2005, p. 53).

IMPORTANCE OF HISTORICAL NARRATIVES: PANGLONG

During our fieldwork, the main point of reference vis-à-vis the Kachin conflict — almost universally raised by respondents — was the narrative of the 1947 Panglong Agreement and the processes around independence. This is the dominant narrative used to articulate contemporary Kachin claims (see also Seng Maw Lahpai 2013; Walton 2008). It combines historical memory with a degree of mythology, as nationalist narratives do, and its centrality to contemporary claims demonstrates its centrality to the process of 'ethnic' mobilization. The creation of a shared sense of historical identity is central to the construction of nationalism, and is used to articulate and legitimize particular claims (Halbwachs 1992 in Walton 2008).

The narrative argues that, before British colonialism, the Kachin hills were never significantly or consistently brought under the control of the Burmese kingdoms, and this degree of separation was perpetuated by the British administration through the separate administration of the 'Frontier Areas'. As independence was being discussed, the Kachin's initial hope was for a future independent of the Burman state — despite strong Kachin representation in the national army, police, and civil service. The narrative continues that the agreement to create the 'Union' of Burma at the Second Panglong Conference, signed by Kachin, Shan, Chin, and Burman representatives on 12 February 1947 (with Karen observers present), was largely based on trust in the Burman leader Aung San, the architect of